
Handout - Loux & Crisp “Persistence Through Time: Endurantism vs. Perdurantism”

I. The Problem: What Is It for a Concrete Particular to Persist?

At the heart of this chapter lies a deceptively simple question:

What does it mean for one and the same concrete particular to exist at different times?

We ordinarily make **claims of diachronic sameness**. These are claims that an object existing at one time is *the very same object* existing at another time (pp. 224–25). I existed yesterday and exist today. The desk I wrote on ten minutes ago is the same desk I write on now. These beliefs are deeply embedded in our self-conception and our understanding of experience.

Yet once we ask what *grounds* such persistence, metaphysicians divide sharply.

The chapter presents two fundamentally different ontological pictures:

- **Endurantism:** Persistence is *numerical identity across time*.
- **Perdurantism:** Persistence consists in having *distinct temporal parts* at different times.

The problem is intensified by **change**. Objects not only persist; they *change*. How can something remain numerically identical while having incompatible properties at different times?

The remainder of the chapter develops these two theories, situates them within broader theories of time, and examines two major arguments for perdurantism.

II. Two Theories of Persistence

A. Endurantism: Three-Dimensionalism

Core thesis:

A concrete particular persists by existing *wholly and completely* at different times (pp. 224–25).

Key commitments:

- Objects are **three-dimensional beings**.
- They have **spatial parts**, but *no temporal parts*.
- Persistence is *literal numerical identity* over time.
- “The Loux of yesterday” and “the Loux of today” refer to **one and the same object**.

Thus, when Henry is tan in the summer and pale in the fall, it is *one and the same Henry* who exemplifies different properties at different times.

Endurantism treats:

- Diachronic sameness as genuine identity.
- The notion of enduring identity as ontologically basic.

B. Perdurantism: Four-Dimensionalism**Core thesis:**

A concrete particular persists by having **different temporal parts** at different times (pp. 225–27).

Key commitments:

- Objects are **four-dimensional “spacetime worms.”**
- They have both **spatial parts and temporal parts**.
- “The Loux of yesterday” and “the Loux of today” refer to *distinct temporal parts*.

Persistence is not identity across time but rather:

Being an aggregate of temporal parts appropriately related.

Important features:

- Temporal parts are fully concrete.
- There may be instantaneous temporal slices (debated).
- Temporal parts can overlap.
- The whole object does not strictly exist at a time; only its temporal parts do (p. 227).

This yields a radically different ontology.

III. Persistence and Theories of Time

The debate maps closely onto broader views about time (pp. 227–31).

A. The B-Theory (Eternalism)

- All times are equally real.
- Reality is a four-dimensional block.
- Objects are naturally conceived as spacetime worms.

Natural pairing:

B-theory + Perdurantism.

Endurantism can be combined with eternalism, but Loux argues this pairing is unstable (pp. 227–28).

B. The A-Theory

Includes:

- Growing block
- Shrinking block
- Spotlight view
- **Presentism**

Most A-theories are compatible with perdurantism—except:

Presentism

- Only the present exists.
- Past and future objects do not exist.

Since non-present entities cannot be parts of present things:

Presentism entails endurantism (pp. 228–29).

Thus the dominant pairings:

Theory of Time

Eternalism (B-theory)

Presentism

Theory of Persistence

Perdurantism

Endurantism

IV. The Ontology of Perdurantism

Perdurantism implies a vastly expanded ontology (pp. 231–33).

If objects are spacetime regions filled with matter, then:

Any filled region of spacetime is a material object.

This includes bizarre objects like “**Athanasius**”—a gerrymandered object composed of:

- Loux yesterday,
- Big Ben (1914–16),
- Wembley Stadium (1954),
- Part of the Sears Tower (1994).

Perdurantists accept:

- Infinitely many material objects.
- No ontologically privileged way of carving spacetime.
- Familiar objects are distinguished by relations among parts:
 - Spatiotemporal continuity
 - Similarity
 - Causal connectedness

Familiar objects are continuous spacetime worms with:

- Adjacent temporal parts
- Gradual qualitative change
- Causal dependence across stages (pp. 233–34)

Endurantists reject this entire framework as ontologically profligate.

V. First Argument for Perdurantism: Change in Properties

The Henry Case (pp. 236–37)

Henry is:

- Tan in summer
- Pale in fall

Endurantism claims:

Henry-in-summer = Henry-in-fall.

But the **Indiscernibility of Identicals** states:

If $a = b$, then they share all properties.

Since:

- Henry-in-summer is tan
- Henry-in-fall is not tan

Endurantism seems committed to contradiction.

Endurantist Response: Time-Indexed Properties

Henry does not have incompatible properties simpliciter. Rather:

- He is tan-in-summer.
- He is not-tan-in-fall.

Further, if we are **presentists**, tensed language is fundamental:

- Henry *was* tan.
- Henry *is now* pale.

Once tenses are respected, no violation of indiscernibility occurs (pp. 238–39).

Thus:

- The perdurantist argument presupposes eternalism.
 - On presentism, identity through change is coherent.
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VI. Second Argument: Change in Parts

This is the more powerful argument.

The Descartes Case (pp. 240–42)

Before time t :

- Descartes has a left hand.
- Descartes-Minus (all but the left hand) also exists.

At t :

- The hand is amputated.

After t :

- Descartes survives.
- Descartes-Minus survives.
- They are spatially coincident.

Endurantism appears committed to:

1. Descartes-before = Descartes-after
2. Descartes-Minus-before = Descartes-Minus-after
3. Descartes-after = Descartes-Minus-after

By transitivity:

4. Descartes-before = Descartes-Minus-before

But this is false (they differ in properties).

Thus endurantism seems inconsistent.

VII. Endurantist Strategies of Response

Loux surveys several responses:

1. Mereological Essentialism (Chisholm)

- Objects cannot survive loss of parts.
- Only “loose and popular” sameness applies to everyday objects.
- Strict identity applies only to primary entities (pp. 243–44).

Cost: radical revision of common-sense ontology.

2. Relative Identity (Geach)

- Identity is always relative to a sortal.
- Same human $\neq$ same collection of cells (pp. 245–46).

Transitivity holds only within the same identity relation.

Cost: rejection of a single absolute identity relation.

3. Spatial Coincidence

- Two numerically distinct objects can occupy the same region.
- Descartes and Descartes-Minus are distinct but coincident (p. 246).

Cost: acceptance of coincident objects.

4. Denial of Arbitrary Undetached Parts (van Inwagen)

- There is no such thing as Descartes-Minus.
- Rejects gerrymandered objects (p. 247).

Cost: highly restrictive mereology.

VIII. The Dialectical Stalemate

Perdurantists argue:

- Endurantist strategies are counterintuitive.
- Perdurantism explains change more cleanly.
- Spatiotemporal boundaries are essential.

Endurantists counter:

- Perdurantism denies obvious modal intuitions.
- Churchill could have lived longer—but perdurantism denies this.
- Temporal parts are absent from prephilosophical thought (pp. 247–48).

The debate parallels the modal debate between:

- **Lewis's possibilism** (analogous to perdurantism)
- **Plantinga's actualism** (analogous to endurantism)

Both debates concern whether persistence/identity across frames (worlds or times) is:

- Genuine identity
or
 - Aggregative structure across distinct entities.
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